The Chemistry of Contentment

By **BHARAT THAKUR**



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Contentment is difficult to define, especially in physiological and material terms, because it has so many dimensions, layers, ingredients, juices and flavours. It is about the interactions of all of these and the net effect they produce. There is a soup of hormones that your body secretes to get there:

Endorphins are neurotransmitters that are the body's natural painkillers. They are powerful analgesics produced by the hypothalamus and pituitary glands of the brain in response to stress and pain. While running for a long distance, you may find yourself wanting to stop out of exhaustion. But if you endure, you feel a surge of energy. It's called the 'runner's high' or 'the second wind'. When you do an activity beyond your threshold, endorphins are released, so that you can ignore the pain and go on. Regular exercise, yoga, brisk walks, exposure to sun, meditation, music, dance, laughter and intimacy keep the endorphin pathways robust and active.

Dopamine is also a neurotransmitter called the 'reward chemical'. When we feel hungry, we reach out for food we like, anticipating that it will satisfy our hunger. When it does, the action feels pleasurable, and so we get conditioned to reach out for it when we are hungry. The anticipation of the feeling of reward motivates us, and the pleasure comes from the release of dopamine. When we crack a puzzle or a game for the first time, it feels good. But we don't get the same high when we repeat it. So, we crave a new high. This increasing craving is said to be the neurobiological basis of seeking out new adventures and taking higher risks. Dopamine also gives you an appetite for learning and makes you attentive, it keeps your memory sharp, it is a great stimulant for creativity, and it makes you super-confident.

Serotonin is called the 'happy hormone'. It is the main "feelgood" chemical because it plays a huge role in regulating our moods. If serotonin is at normal levels, you feel focused, emotionally stable, optimistic and calm. Conversely, low levels are associated with depression. Did you know that 90 per cent of the body's serotonin is made in the gut, where it helps control your bowel function and speeds up digestion? It gives you the feeling of satiation after a nice meal and makes us say 'enough' for even foods we love. When serotonin and dopamine levels are adequate, you get quality sleep.

Oxytocin is called the 'love hormone' because it is the one that promotes bonding between mother and baby. Every time the mother feeds the baby, oxytocin floods her bloodstream, deepening the mother-child bond. Oxytocin also flows freely during intimate moments between lovers, when you bond with a friend, and even when you cuddle your pet or adore your plants. Oxytocin also encourages one to be drawn to people they identify with and disconnect from people they don't.

Each one of these hormones seems to take care of different aspects of our good feelings. Each is multi-dimensional and fundamentally connected with the health of our vital organs. Nature seems to activate these feelgood chemicals through our simple choices and actions. Well-being, it seems, is not intended to be understood and cracked like a formula, but lived, felt and immersed in. ■

HAPPINESS MANTRA

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Bharat Thakur is a spiritual teacher and renowned yoga expert